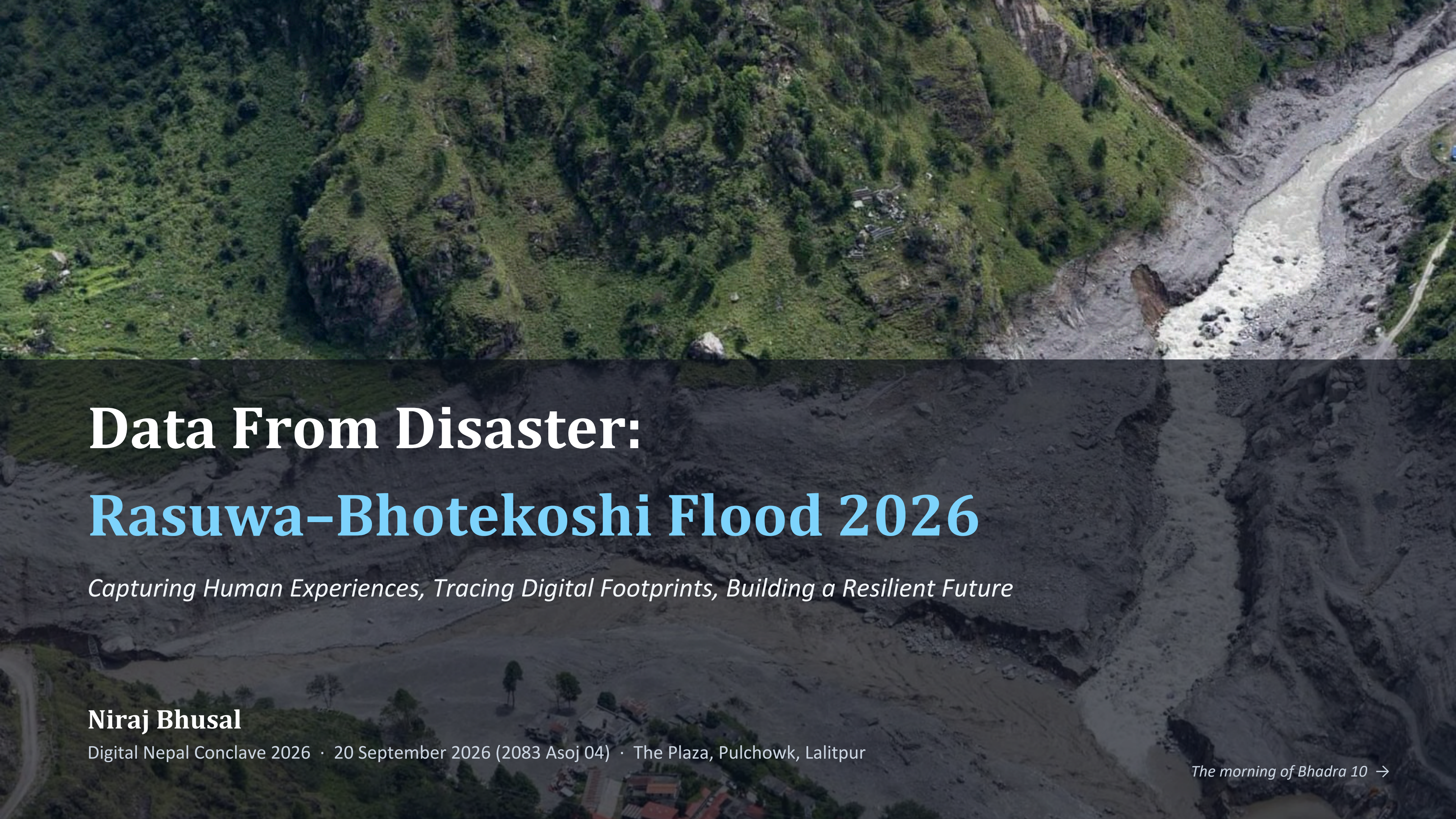


An aerial photograph of a river valley. The top half shows a lush green hillside with a river flowing through it. The bottom half shows a large, dark, muddy flood area that has inundated the valley floor, covering the river and surrounding land. The text is overlaid on the flood area.

Data From Disaster: Rasuwa–Bhotekoshi Flood 2026

Capturing Human Experiences, Tracing Digital Footprints, Building a Resilient Future

Niraj Bhusal

Digital Nepal Conclave 2026 · 20 September 2026 (2083 Asoj 04) · The Plaza, Pulchowk, Lalitpur

The morning of Bhadra 10 →

Where the idea came from: the morning of Bhadra 10.

The information existed. It just could not reach the people asking for it.

1

Bhadra 10 (26 August), morning

Getting ready for an ordinary day at the Ministry of Finance when the news arrived: the Rasuwagadhi customs office on the Nepal–China border had been swept away.

2

Within hours

The Bhotekoshi and Trishuli had taken roads, bridges, hydropower plants and settlements. Far less clear: how many were missing, where rescue teams were, which numbers were official and which were rumour.

3

The information existed

NDRRMA situation reports. Police and Army updates. DHM river data. Scattered across PDFs, JPGs, Facebook posts and press notes, almost entirely in Nepali.

4

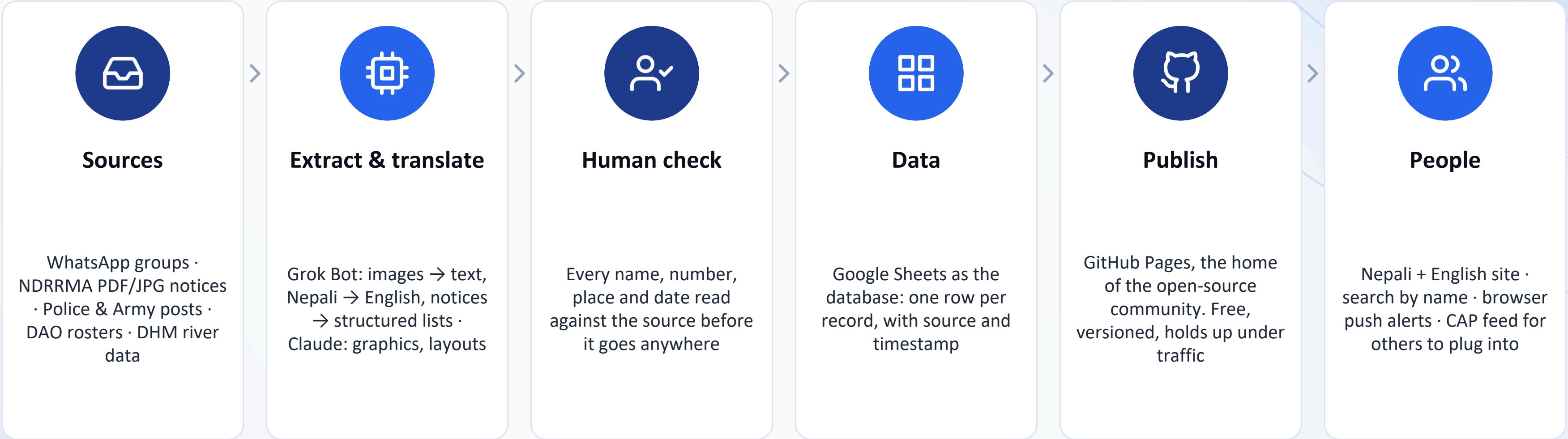
The one question

None of it was searchable by the question every family was asking: is my person on any list? The portal started that day.

Misinformation does not spread only because falsehood is created. It spreads because the truth arrives late, fragmented, or locked behind a language barrier.

Built with what was already on the desk, the same day.

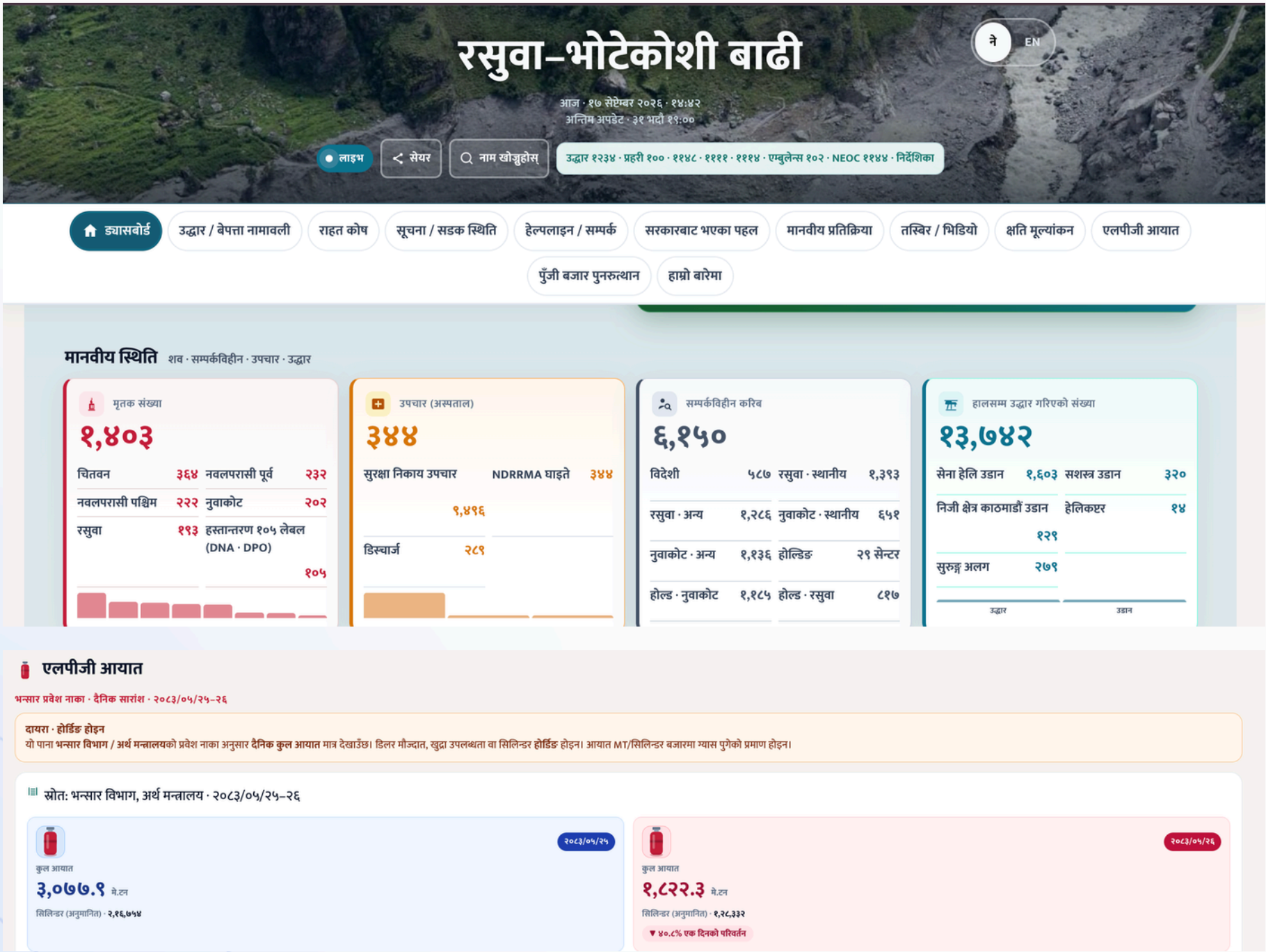
In a crisis, verified information must travel at least as fast as misinformation. So, that day, with what was on the desk:



The whole stack: laptop · GitHub · Google Sheets · Claude · Grok Bot. **Budget:** AI credits, some given by supporters. No procurement, no vendor, no server.

One person. One day. A bilingual bulletin on official data.

Built in a personal capacity during the flood; later adopted into MoF’s public-information infrastructure.



Aggregation

Verified updates, one place.



Translation

Nepali → English, human-checked.



Readable lists

Photos → structured lists.



Search by name

Missing, rescued, found.



Scan to view

How you talk to the tools matters →

Talk to the AI like your doctor. Then let a human publish.

We tell a doctor everything and get real medicine. We hide things from a lawyer and lose the case. AI works the same way: AI drafts, a human publishes.



Delegate

AI drafted every graphic and list. A human decided what was published.



Describe

“Clean, official colours, Nepali + English, footer QR to donate.gov.np. Verify data.”



Discern

Every figure read back against the NDRRMA notice before it went live.



Diligence

Only what the state had already published. No private details of the missing into a chatbot.

“Update this.” One instruction, one human check, one live site.



New notice

A PDF or JPG, in Nepali



“Update this”

One-line instruction to the bot



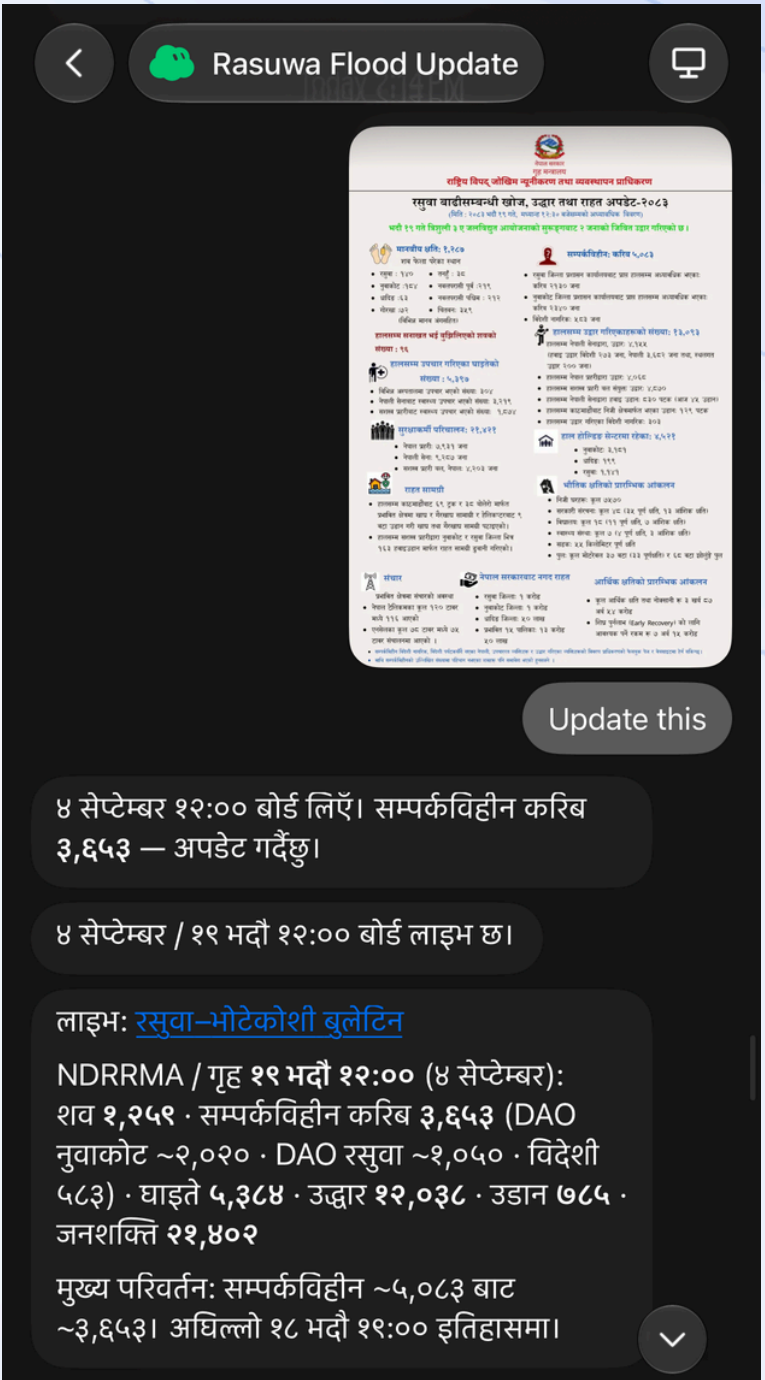
Bot reads & verifies

Extracts, cross-checks figures



Site updated

Human reviews, then publishes



“Build what you’d want if it were your family.”

In a crisis, language is a wall. I could translate one notice. Not fifty.



She sent a photo of the notice

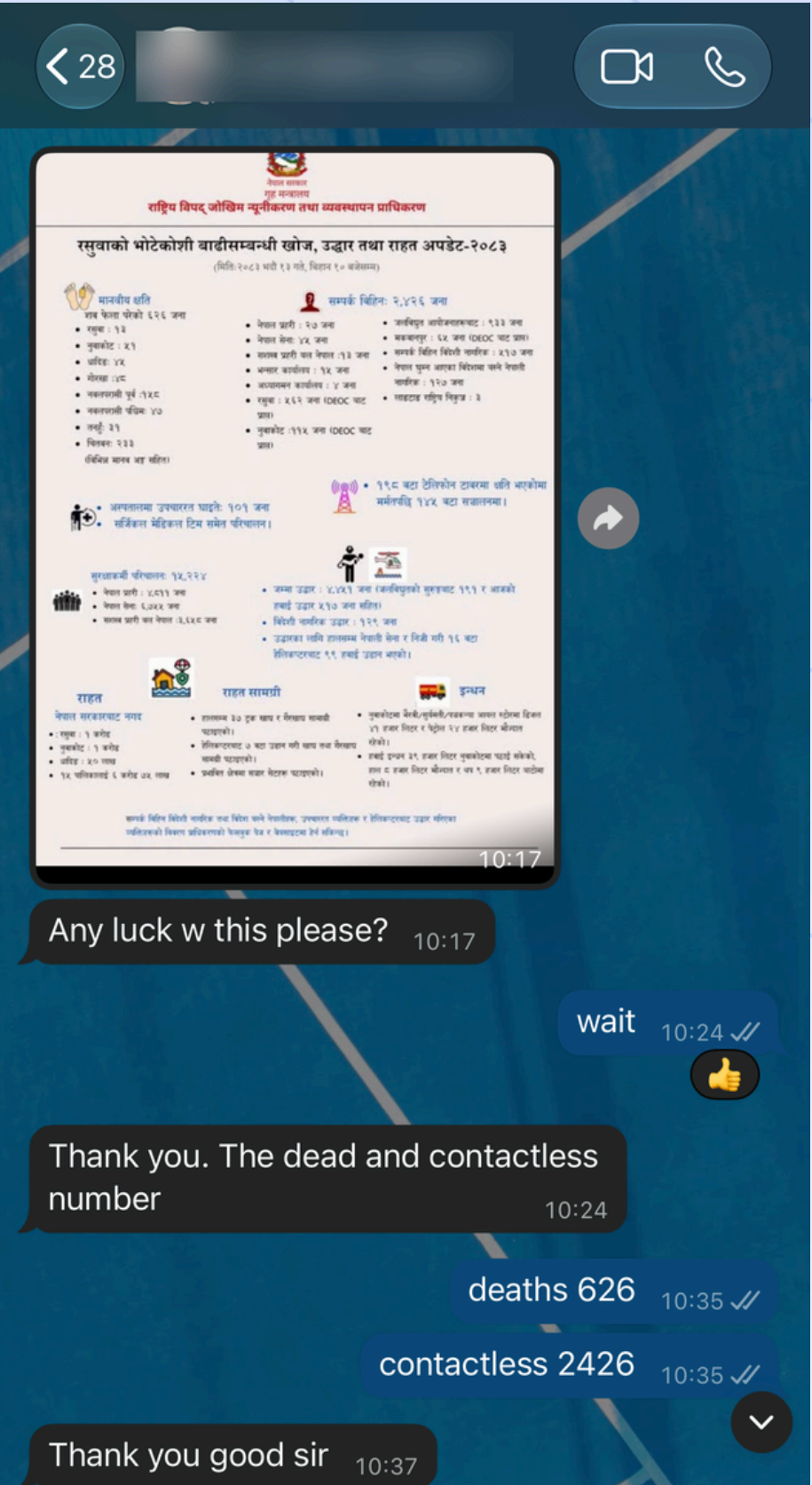
Nepali numerals, Nepali script, no text layer: unreadable to search engines and to her newsroom.



I translated two numbers



An international newsroom reported them



One list, one missing name →

“An information vacuum is itself a disinformation vulnerability.”

The list



How it was shared

Phone photographs of paper, forwarded group to group. Tilted, cropped, sometimes missing a page.



How families used it

Zooming into every page on a small screen, looking for one name, one village, one age.



What one redesign did

Re-typed, structured and republished as a searchable list, with the source document clearly identified.



What it taught

Paper data is data no one can search. A family should not scroll pages of images to learn whether a name appears.

The missing



Identification

DNA · NID (biometrics / fingerprints)



The gap

Misinformation grew in the gap. People invented their own version.

The flood also left a false footprint.

A viral post: “Messi donated \$2.3M to Nepal.”

#1

Misinformation & disinformation: the top technological risk in the WEF Global Risks Report 2025.

Source: WEF Global Risks Perception Survey 2024–25

The antidote is not a fact-check after the fact.

Misinformation travels fast because nobody checks it. Verified information can travel nearly as fast if checking is narrowed to source selection and final review.

A digital footprint is left by everyone who posts, including those who are wrong.



Niraj Bhusal

@nirajbhusal

X.com

The claim is not supported by evidence. There is no confirmation from Lionel Messi, the Leo Messi Foundation, ESPN Argentina, or any major news outlet that the foundation donated over \$2.3 million for Nepal’s August 2026 floods. The graphic citing ESPN Argentina does not match any published article from that outlet.



SK10

@SK10_Football · 5d

Leo Messi has donated over \$2.3M in aid through the Leo Messi Foundation for flood affected communities in Nepal. [Via:ESPN_Argentina] 🇳🇵 🇦🇷

GOAT on and off the field 🐐 🙏



@nirajbhusal, X, September 2026

Ministry's official portal.

The same workflow, now institutional: verified sources in, bilingual, machine-readable, published by the Ministry of Finance.



Contributions, by channel

NPR 14.25 bn to the PM Disaster Relief Fund: NCHL and Fonepay online (11.9 lakh transactions), handovers to the Finance Minister (453 donors), foreign assistance in USD.



Government initiatives

Business Recovery Plan, first phase: 18 relief measures across Customs, Inland Revenue, Nepal Rastra Bank and the Insurance Authority, searchable by agency.



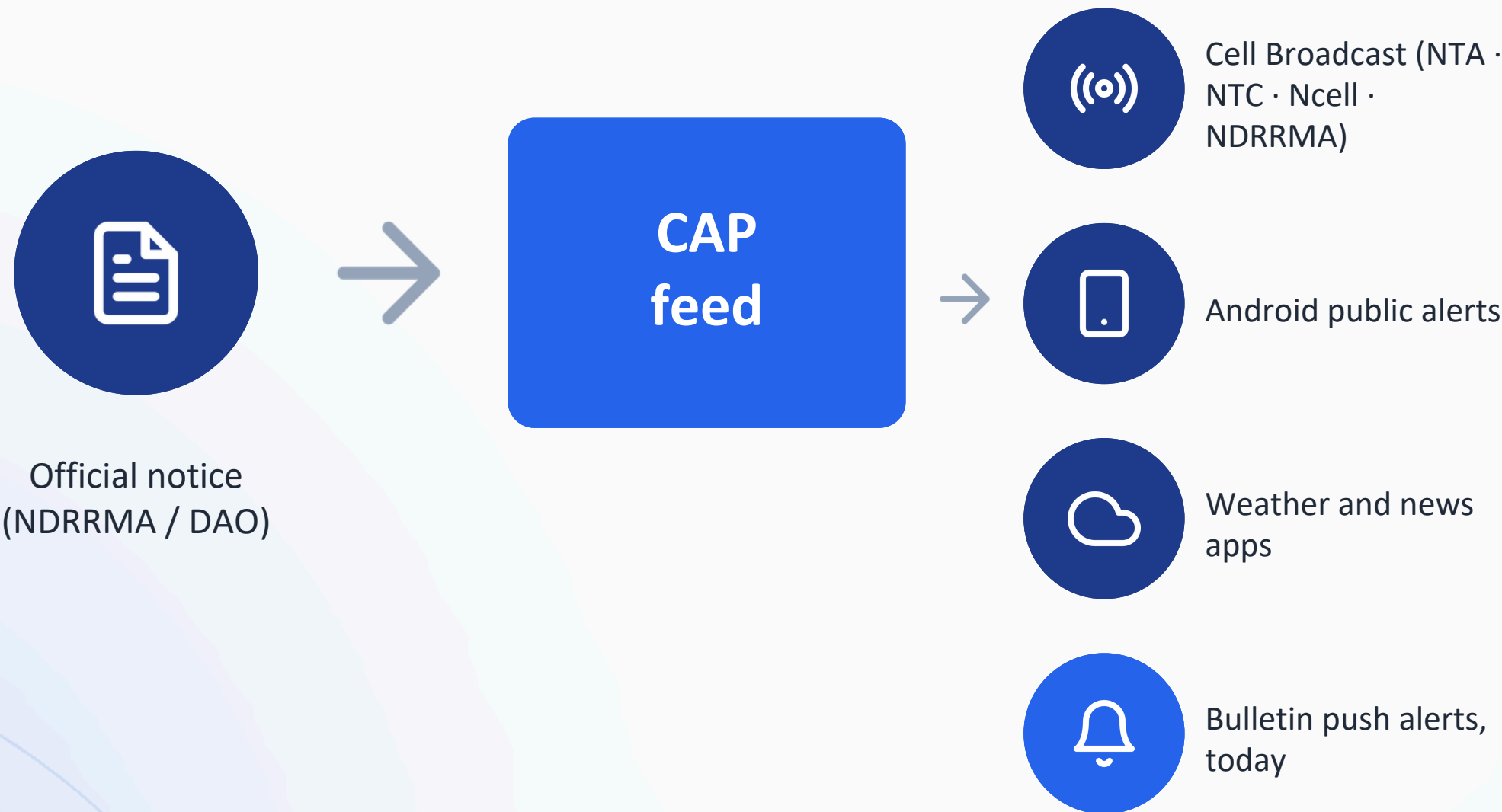
Action plans with deadlines

21-point Capital Market Recovery Plan: responsible agency and due date for every point, with the source document attached.

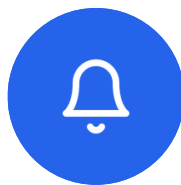
Warn a whole valley at once. And what we can do until then.

Cell Broadcast, the technology behind the Amber Alert / Wireless Emergency Alerts. It needs four institutions; two things are possible today.

One notice, one format, every channel



UNTIL THEN, TWO THINGS TODAY



1 · Push alerts

Phone-app alerts, like the Nagarik App or the Bipad Alert App: every notice arrives on the screen as a push alert.



2 · Every notice published in CAP

Common Alerting Protocol: the international format read by Cell Broadcast, Google’s Android alerts and weather apps. NDRRMA or a telecom can connect to it directly.

Defaults for the next disaster.

A human-in-the-loop model any office can run: verified sources in, humans judge.



Structured, attributed, versioned

Parallel Nepali–English text with source and time. Lists as searchable data, not documents. Show corrections instead of silently overwriting them. Sources only from named institutions: DAO, NDRRMA, security agencies, hospitals. AI transforms; a reviewer approves every name, number, place and date.



A Digital Highway

Verified data is one lane. The road is Nepal's shared digital infrastructure: digital identity, digital payments, data exchange between agencies, public alerts and open data, built once and used by every office. The physical highway to Rasuwa took years to build and a night to lose. .

Resilience is not measured by how much data a disaster generates, but by how fast verified data reaches the people who need it.

Thank you

Niraj Bhusal

Ministry of Finance, Government of Nepal
Office of the Hon'ble Finance Minister

Master's in Information and Communication Engineering, HUST, China · AI Governance, ITU,
Geneva · Perplexity AI Fellow · GovTech Nepal



**Rasuwa-Bhotekoshi Flood
Bulletin**

nirajbhusal.github.io/rasuwa-flood-bulletin



MoF Flood Update Portal

mofnepal.github.io/rasuwa-flood-update

Scan, then build your own.